

Ultimate Poetry Slam

Giles sat at a bare wooden table in an otherwise empty, dimly lit cell. Somewhere in the building, his opponent must be similarly situated, but he couldn't worry about that. He was feverishly writing, casting sheets of paper to the side when he had filled them. He was resolved to prevail in this endurance contest -- who could maintain a stream of poetry for the longest period of time.

The manager of his opponent had other ideas. He knew that Giles could not resist the smell of pastry, and so he had a plate piled high with scones brought to his cell. Giles momentarily put down his pen. Surely one quick scone couldn't hurt. But soon he was shoveling them into his mouth with both hands. Within seconds he would be disqualified by reason of a break in his creative activity. This realization struck him, and he pushed the plate aside and went back to his versifying. The manager had one more trick. He piped into the cell a rap version of "I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud" repeating endlessly at mind-numbing volume. That should do it.

The next morning, Giles emerged from the cell, haggard but victorious. The manager stared at Giles, mouth open in disbelief. Giles couldn't resist taunting him, chanting "Stacks of scones may break my poems but Wordsworth never harmed me."

